

Download Managers

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People who were managing with a mere 160 GB hard drive today have the option of upgrading to a 500 GB hard drive for more or less the same price that they would have paid two years back for their current drive. Gone are the good old days of 56.6 kbps modems; today you can get a 1 Mbps unlimited Internet connection for about Rs 2,500 per month. So what do you do when you have a couple of terabytes of hard drive space and a fast Internet connection? Well, you download everything you possibly can; and thanks to fixed rate, unlimited download plans a new breed of junkie has spawned — the download junkie. Download Managers are software that have been designed for the purpose of

Download managers will help reduce your blood pressure problems, which are caused by unreliable Internet connectivity

making your downloading as much a streamlined, automatic process that can happily run without your interference. After all, who wants to sit in front of his PC while it downloads 20 gigabytes of data on a 512 kbps connection?

Many people also have discrete download machines; PCs which are solely used to download from the Internet; and they use a different PC for gaming, multimedia and so on. In such cases, a download manager becomes even more important; since it's annoying to have to monitor downloads every little while. Download managers are designed to give users a greater control over the files they are downloading. Of course one might ask why not just use a Web browser to download files. Well, browsers cannot split up down-

loads into segments. On the other hand, download managers are developed for this kind of thing. We bring you the Top 5 download managers, tested and served up for you to choose from.

Free Download Manager 2.5
Free Download Manager (FDM here on), as the name suggests is free. It has possibly the most features we have seen in a download manager including Flash video downloads, BitTorrent support, Remote Access, etc. FDM impressed us a lot with its easy-to-use GUI.

FDM has a feature called Community Opinions. Here, the comments and feedback from other users are displayed about the file you are downloading. Also you can add your own thoughts about it which will be read by

.MP3 files into a music subfolder.

Bandwidth Allocation: Setting a speed limit or cap for your download is a very useful feature. By doing this you can surf normally while your file is still being downloaded with no problems of a Web site not opening due to bandwidth being hogged by the download that's happening simultaneously.

Flash Video Download: Flash video sites like Youtube and Google Videos have become a craze. Not only do users want to watch the videos online but also want to download the ones they like. So now some Download Managers have implemented the feature that lets you directly download Flash videos off these Web sites.

Browser Plug-in: A Download Manager that integrates with Web browsers is very helpful and gives easy access to users for instant downloads. We looked at how well the download manager integrated with the browser. The simpler it is the more usable it will be.

BitTorrent Support: BitTorrent downloads have become a very popular means of download. Having BitTorrent protocol integrated in a Download Manager makes downloading much easier as you don't need a second program just to download BitTorrent files.

Scheduler: Ever had an Internet connection that gave you cheaper or free rates at night or for certain part of the day? With these limited connections, downloads should be scheduled so that you don't go beyond the time limits and end up paying a hefty bill at the end of the month. If your download manager has a scheduler feature inbuilt, you need not worry anymore. Schedulers can now start and stop downloads and even connect on demand.

Remote Access: A more advanced feature available in Download Managers is that of remote access where in you can control and check on the progress of your downloads, even if you are not at your PC.

How We Tested

How We Tested: We jotted down the main features that are expected in a Download Manager and tested the performance in terms of memory usage and download speed over a 2 Mbps dedicated connection. We downloaded a 27.5 MB file from a stable server 5 times each. We tried to keep the testing a bit more realistic and used a lower-end PC.

PC Configuration:

- Intel P4 @ 3.40GHz
- 768 MB DDR1 RAM
- Windows XP SP2

The features that we looked for are as follows:

Resume support: The resuming of broken or interrupted downloads is one of the primary features that all Download Managers have. This saves a lot of time rather than re-downloading the entire file.

Mirror search support: A feature that any good download manager should have — mirror searches to add more sources for a download. A download manager should have the capability of automatically searching for alternative mirror links of the file that is being downloaded and resume download from any of them if the original download breaks.

Prioritised Downloads: A download manager should have the feature to let the user choose the order of download. Users should be able to either queue a specific download first or allot more bandwidth for it. In this way each file will be downloaded according to the priority set by the user.

Categorised Downloads: A Download Manager should be able to sort the file you are downloading into separate subfolders based on the file extension. Eg. AVI files will be put into a video subfolder and

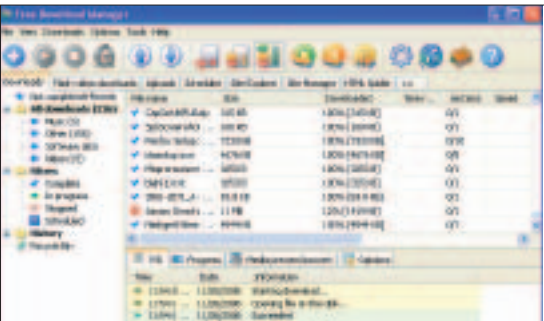
another when downloading the same file. The scheduler provided is not as complicated as we thought it would be. It's straight forward with option of Time, Date, Days (where you can even select which day of the week you wish to run the task), Hours and Minutes. It also includes additional features where a file can be downloaded from several mirrors simultaneously, and only particular files that you need in a zip file can be selected for download.

To download torrents you need to enable the BitTorrent protocol support in the download options. You can set an upload limit and even disable seeding if you want to.

FDM has the feature to download Flash videos straight off sites like YouTube and Google Videos. Just input the URL of the site like any other file download. After it's complete the default output is saved as an .flv file. FDM has its own audio and video convertor which stores files in .AVI, .MPEG4 and even .MP3. It also has preset formats for iPods and PSPs.

The Remote Access feature in FDM is pretty impressive. If you plan to leave your PC unattended but also want to monitor your downloads, or if you suddenly remember to download something else, then this particular feature will prove to be very useful. All that needs to be done is switch on the FDM Remote Control Server. For this to work you have to remember your IP which is displayed on the FDM remote control screen. Downloads can be viewed and new ones can be added using this feature. A username and password can also be set for security purposes. Free Download Manager is the only Download Manager we came across that has this unique feature of Remote Control

FDM also comes with an upload manager called Free Upload Manager. Files were uploaded through wikifortio.com. This did not work, and the files we were trying to upload just refused to do so.



Free Download Manager — Managing multiple downloads easily

FDM used a maximum of 14.5 MB of RAM with a single download and attained a maximum speed of 213 KBps

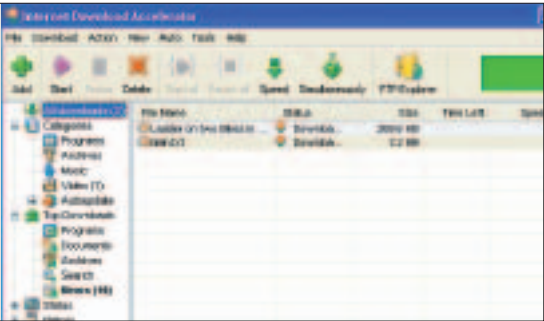
Internet Download Accelerator 5.6

Also known as IDA, this Download Manager is a shareware with a 30 day trial period.

You can set the number of maximum simultaneous downloads and have five variable speed limits. You can set the type of files that can be automatically downloaded or need permission before downloading with their extensions E.g. EXE and ZIP could be set as automatic whereas RAR and AVI could be removed from the list which would mean asking permission for the download. This feature is not present in FDM.

You could also embed an IDA Bar into your Microsoft Internet Explorer browser where you can view and set your download speed, view your downloads via a dropdown menu and also download all the links from the page you are at. A search function is also present which conduct searches through the Web site MyTopFiles.com.

IDA has its own FTP Explorer which pops out as a window when clicked. The FTP Explorer has its



Internet Download Accelerator 5.6

own set of file filters which can be set according to the users wishes. It works the same as FDM but is more user-friendly.

This download manager also has a Site Manager which helps retain information like usernames and passwords for a particular site, thus eliminating the need for re-entering them every time you need to download something from such sites.

IDA has quite a few features but it does not match up to that of FDM which has more advanced features like Remote Access and Video Converter. IDA can download Flash videos but does not have a video converter like FDM. It also does not have BT protocol support. Paying for this Download Manager does not seem like a wise option as you are getting a better one (FDM) for free.

IDA used up more RAM than FDM and reached a maximum of 20.6 MB. The download speed was the same as with FDM.

Download Accelerator Plus 8.7

When you think of Download Managers the first thing that comes to mind is DAP. DAP has been there for ages and is still has a huge following though slowly diminishing thanks to the new and improved download managers that are available.

But even though times have changed, DAP has not evolved much. The GUI has improved from what it used to be and additions like an FTP browser and its own Internet browser have been bundled in the software package; still, it lacks some features like Flash video download and BitTorrent support.

Though it has a FTP browser we were having problems connecting to ftp servers. And if you look at the Internet browser it's definitely based on Microsoft Internet Explorer.

DAP claims to increase your download speed by 400 per cent, but when we tested out the free version it was not performing as per the claims. The download speeds did fluctuate.